

retirement accounts to pay off the debt. Mort chose this course of action and had to painfully watch about 50 percent of his money disappear after he was taxed and penalized for taking out this money before he reached the allowed disbursement age of fifty-nine and one-half.

Linda's financial relationship to Mort was analogous to that of a daughter receiving an allowance from her father. There was obviously no money communication beyond doling out the money. There were no discussions as to where it was spent or what was bought. Therefore, it was easy for Linda's debt to spiral out of control without Mort's knowledge.

Hidden stashes and concealed purchases are the symptoms of deeper relationship issues. If money is hidden so that a quick getaway from the relationship is possible, what does that say about the belief in "Til death do us part?" If purchases are hidden because the other partner might get angry, what does that say about the commitment to trust? The *Redbook* Poll found that 72 percent said that trust was essential to a successful romance.

There is nothing wrong with maintaining separate accounts, as long as there is frequent communication as to the financial activity that is taking place. Couples have many choices to make concerning where they keep their money if they both work:

- Combine it all into one joint account.
- Keep entirely separate accounts.
- Maintain a combination of both joint and separate accounts.

Once these decisions are made, it needs to be determined who will pay what. Do you assign certain bills to each partner? Does one person pay the rent while the other makes the car payment? Do you lump all the money together and pay the bills from the communal total?

